RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

Prophecy: Who Can Become a Prophet? Principle 6

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 12

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: Principle 6 (prophecy), with the opening of Principle 7 (Moshe's prophecy)

Shiur: Part 12 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 6 January 2026 (the first shiur of the new term, the week after Asarah b'Tevet)

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where the Thirteen Stand

The first section of the Introduction was about **Olam HaBa**. The Rambam (in his **mid-twenties**) then sets out **the fundamentals a person needs for a portion in Olam HaBa**. Last term we did **the first five**:

#	Principle
1	Hashem **exists**, is omnipotent and involved in the world
2	**Yichud**: His oneness, in the refined sense
3	**אין לו גוף ואינו דמות הגוף**: no body. **The only principle with no source** in Torah, Tanach or Chazal
4	Hashem **precedes all**; the correct view is **creation from nothing**, not an eternal world
5	Serve **nothing and no one** besides Hashem: *avodah zarah*

Three categories (Rav Yosef Albo)

Principles	Theme
1–5	**Hashem Himself**: existence, unity, incorporeality, creation, sole worship
6–9	**The relationship between Hashem and humanity**: **prophecy** (6), **Moshe's unique prophecy** (7), **Torah** (8, 9), revelation and instruction
10–13	**Reward and punishment**, in the broad sense

Tonight begins the second category.

Part 1: The Principle Itself

היסוד הששי: הנבואה. והוא שידע האדם שזה מין האדם ימצאו בהם בעלי טבעים ומדות מעולות מאד ושלמות גדולה, ונפשותיהם נכונות עד שיקבלו צורת השכל. אחר כן ידבק אותו השכל האנושי בשכל הפועל, ונאצל ממנו עליו אצילות נכבד. ואלה הם הנביאים, וזו היא הנבואה, וזה ענינה.

Translation:

- Within the human race there are people of **exceptional nature and character** and **great perfection**, whose souls are so prepared that they **fully realise their intellect**.

- That human intellect then **cleaves to the Active Intellect**.

- From it, a great ***atzilut*** flows down upon them. ("How would we translate *atzilut*? A great **flow**. A great **divesting down**.")

- **These are the prophets. This is prophecy.**

וביאור יסוד זה על בוריו ארוך מאד, ואין כוונתנו להביא מופת על כל יסוד מהם... לפי שזהו כלל החכמה כולה, אבל הזכרתה דרך סיפור בלבד. ומקראי התורה מעידים על נבואת נביאים הרבה.

To explain this fully would take very long. My purpose isn't to **prove** each principle, since this is **a whole science**. I mention it **only briefly**. The Torah's verses attest to **many prophets**.

What the principle is, and isn't

"**The sixth principle is not that the words of the *Nevi'im* are true.** That belongs to **principles 8 and 9**, that the Torah is true and divine. The point here is that **there *is* a concept of prophecy**: **Hashem speaks to perfected humans.**"

Formulation	Says	Accurate?
Ani Ma'amin (late 1400s/early 1500s, author unclear): **אני מאמין באמונה שלמה שכל דברי נביאים אמת**	**The prophets' words are true**	"**That's not the point of the principle. That's not correct.**"
Yigdal: שפע נבואתו נתנו אל אנשי סגולתו ותפארתו	Hashem gave **His flow of prophecy** to **His chosen, special people**	"**Much more precise.**"

Why it's a principle in its own right

Hashem is involved in the world. The **Ramban, end of Parashat Bo**: the whole purpose of **Mitzrayim and the ten plagues**. **Pharaoh believed in a divine power**, but not one that **communicates with and cares about humanity**. Hence **כי אני ה׳ בקרב הארץ: I am Hashem in the midst of the land.**

"**God didn't create the world and leave us.** He gave us a Torah (later principles) and also **constant instruction**, at least **until the destruction of the Beit HaMikdash**."

Part 2: Dreams, *Ruach HaKodesh* and Prophecy

People often **confuse** prophecy with **dreams** and with ***Ruach HaKodesh***. **Their only common ground: each reveals information from a lofty spiritual source.** *(This three-level framework is*

the Ramchal's; see the caveat below.)

1. Dreams: "one-sixtieth of prophecy" (Gemara)

Why we wash our hands in the morning:

Reason	Source
Our hands **moved and touched** parts of the body overnight; wash before prayer	**The Rambam** (*al derech hapeshat*)
Like the **Kohanim washing** before the Temple service: **preparing to serve Hashem**	**The Rashba**
At night **soul and body part**; the soul **goes heavenward to recharge**. The **vacuum** draws ***tumah***, so we wash the **extremities**	**The Zohar** (hence **אלהי נשמה שנתת בי טהורה**: "*You've given me back* my soul". "That's not the simple meaning.")

The Ben Ish Chai: really we should wash the whole body daily; Chazal limited it to the hands, the body's "tips" (and "really the toes too: a different discussion").

The Ramchal on dreams: in the body the soul is **suppressed**. Freed at night, it **meets spiritual entities**, which may tell it about **the future**, and that is **transmitted down**: **a dream is a fuzzy transmission.** *(The Rambam: "To the best of my knowledge he doesn't discuss how dreams work.")*

But not every heavenly force is good: *malachei chabalah* convey **false, fabricated messages**. Hence the contradiction:

Zechariah: חלומות השוא ידברו: dreams speak falsehood. **Yet the end of Bereishit** is all dreams: **Yosef's, Pharaoh's, everyone's.**

Answer: it depends on the source.

Rule	Why
A dream follows its interpretation	We **can't know** whether its source is true
A repeated dream is taken seriously	why does the Torah stress that Pharaoh **slept and** :**ויישן ויחלם שנית** ?**dreamt again**
Interpret positively	Even a true, bad dream **can be changed by reframing it**

"**I remember one person who every week would call us together as a *beit din* to annul his dreams.** *Zichrono livrachah.* Some people get **very afraid** of dreams."

2. *Ruach HaKodesh*: divine intuition

Talmai's 72 Sages (from Asarah b'Tevet last week): each translating separately, they were **all divinely inspired to make the same changes**. "**That's not prophecy.** They weren't having a prophetic experience. **It was *Ruach HaKodesh*: divine intuition.**"

The Ramchal, *Derech Hashem*:

> יקרה שיושפע בלב האדם שפע שיעמידהו על תוכן ענין מהענינים... a flow **suddenly gives you understanding** of something. **Sometimes you won't notice it**: אלא כמי שנופלת מחשבה בלבבו **like a thought just fell into your heart.**

"**A brilliant idea in Yiddish is an *einfall*: it fell from above**. You're confused, and suddenly **it all falls into place**, and you feel **divinely inspired**. **I think humans experience that.** But it's completely different from prophecy."

3. Prophecy: an experience

	Dreams	*Ruach HaKodesh*	Prophecy
When	Asleep	**Awake**	Awake (stripped of the senses)
What	Information, **true or false**	**Intuition**, a thought that "falls in"	**A Godly experience**
Clarity	Fuzzy	You may not even notice	**Total clarity**
Essence	A message	An insight	**Becoming a different person**

"**It's a big mistake to think prophecy is Hashem giving you extra information.** That's a possible **side effect**. **The essence is a Godly experience.**"

Proof: the Gemara (Megillah) implies **at least 1.2 million prophets** (below). "**How many books of prophets do we have? We can count them on our fingers.** We don't have their messages, **because the message isn't the essence.**"

And it doesn't endure: "**Prophecy for half an hour today doesn't mean tomorrow.** You may have it **once in your life**." Hence the ***Bnei HaNevi'im***: "**like medical school or law school, there was literally a school for prophets**, where they **practised receiving prophecy**."

> **The Rambam, Hilchot Yesodei HaTorah 7:1: בעת שתנוח עליו הרוח תתערב נפשו במעלת המלאכים הנקראים אישים, ויהפך לאיש אחר, ויבין בדעתו שאינו כמו שהיה אלא שנתעלה על מעלת שאר בני אדם החכמים, כמו שנאמר בשאול: והתנבית עמם ונהפכת לאיש אחר.**

When the spirit rests on him, his soul **joins the level of the angels called *ishim***; he **becomes a different person**, and knows he is **not as he was**: as said to **Shaul**: ***you will prophesy with them and become another man***.

The Ramchal, *Derech Hashem*: higher than both is prophecy: **שיגיע האדם ויתקשר בבורא יתברך שמו, ויתדבק בו דביקות ממש in a way he feels the cleaving**, with no doubt. **והנה עיקר הנבואה הוא השג הדבקות והקשר הזה עודו בחיים its essence is attaining this cleaving and connection *while still alive*.**

What is it like?

"**I've got no idea, and it's very hard to describe.** The best analogy: you're led **blindfolded** into a room. For **hours** you grope around, feeling this and that, trying to work out where you are.

Then the blindfold comes off and you see everything. Everything falls into place. That's *nevuah*."

The Rambam (Moreh): comparing prophecy to philosophy is like trying to **pour all the water in the world into one jug**. "I could spend hours **describing this room** to you with your eyes closed, the colours, the books, the furniture; **it can't compare to opening your eyes**."

"All the questions, the philosophy, the investigation we go through in life trying to understand Torah and God: **suddenly your eyes are opened**. **Not to everything**, it's limited. But in whatever you're shown, **you have a whole different understanding of what life is about.**"

Part 3: Who Can Become a Prophet? (Moreh 2:32)

The Moreh has three sections: God, prophecy, reward and punishment, "really the thirteen principles in their three categories." Section two is mostly about prophecy.

Among **those who believe in prophecy** there are three views:

View 1: the masses (*da'at hamon*)

שהאל יתעלה בוחר מי שירצה מבני אדם... ומשלחו

Hashem simply chooses whom He wants. "**You wake up one morning** and Hashem says: you're a prophet."

אין לדעתם הפרש בין היות האיש ההוא חכם או סכל, זקן או נער: **wisdom, age, experience make no difference**. (He must be **a good, decent person**: "Hashem isn't giving prophecy to the wicked.")

The Rambam: the view of the ignorant. It is also **Rabbi Yehudah HaLevi's view in the Kuzari**.

View 2: the philosophers (incl. Aristotle, "who believed in prophecy")

הנבואה היא שלמות מסוימת בטבע האדם: prophecy is **a natural perfection**, reached only after **great training**.

The person perfect in intellect and character, with a **developed imaginative faculty**: **הכרח שיתנבא**: **he must prophesy.**

View 3: the Torah's view (the Rambam's)

היא כדעת הפילוסופית בדיוק, חוץ מדבר אחד: **exactly the philosophers' view, except one thing**, one who is **fit and prepared** may still **not prophesy according to the Divine will.** (He then works through the verses that seem to say otherwise.) **לפי החפץ האלהי**:

	Requirements	Then?	"The miracle is..."
1. The masses / Kuzari	A good person	**Hashem chooses**	**...that you *get* prophecy**
2. Philosophers	Character + intellect + imagination	**Automatic**	No miracle
3. Torah / Rambam	Character + intellect + imagination	**Still Hashem's choice**	**...that you *don't* get it**

"**Views one and three are *miktzeh el katzeh*: from one end to the other.**" For the Rambam, **prophecy doesn't just fall on a person**; you **constantly train and perfect yourself**.

The most consistent thread in all the Rambam's writing: the purpose of humanity is perfecting the intellect and the *middot*. Mitzvot train the **character**; **study of Torah and the sciences** refines the **intellect**.

Question (class): *View 1 seems to equate prophecy with getting a message, which we said isn't prophecy.*

"Not necessarily. Hashem may choose you **just to give you the experience**: **you now understand what other humans don't**, without telling anyone. Sometimes you'll be sent with a message. **The dispute isn't about what prophecy is for; it's about who gets it.**"

Part 4: The Three Ingredients

Hilchot Yesodei HaTorah 7:1: אין הנבואה חלה אלא על חכם גדול בחכמה, גבור במדותיו, ולא יהא יצרו מתגבר עליו בדבר בעולם, אלא הוא מתגבר בדעתו על יצרו תמיד, בעל דעה רחבה נכונה עד מאד.

Moreh 2:36: prophecy is reached only through **השלמות בחכמות העיוניות** (the **theoretical sciences**), **perfecting the *middot*** to their best possible state, together with **the perfection of the imaginative faculty** (***koach hamedameh***) by nature.

Ingredient	What it means	The Rabbi
1. Intellect	**Torah inside out**, a huge *talmid chacham*, **and** the sciences of the world (**not just Torah**: "otherwise he'd say Torah")	"**To understand God, study what He's given us**: the Torah, **and the world He made**. **From His handiwork** you understand how He operates." **Basic sciences**, "not technology"
2. Character	**Never ruled by the *yetzer***: no anger, no lust of the eyes, **no pull of financial gain**	"**We all have dips.** Even such a person **fluctuates**, which is why **sometimes he has prophecy and sometimes not**"
3. Imagination (*ba'al de'ah rechavah*)	**The ability to think broadly**: you see **a boat on a river** and **a bird flying**, and imagine **a boat flying**	"**I've never understood why** this is essential, but the Rambam reiterates it in many places. **Whether that means reading lots of sci-fi**, I'm not sure he means that."

A caveat from the Rabbi: "**I've probably shoehorned the Ramchal into the Rambam.** Here the Rambam seems to **equate *Ruach HaKodesh with nevuah***. The dreams / *Ruach HaKodesh* / prophecy distinction was **straight from the Ramchal**. **I'm not sure the Rambam agrees.** I need to look into that properly."

The 1.2 million prophets

Megillah 14a: הרבה נביאים עמדו להם לישראל, כפלים כיוצאי מצרים: **double those who left Egypt**. 600,000 × 2 = **1.2 million**.

"**Really? 1.2 million people reached the perfection the Rambam describes?** Perhaps. Perhaps we don't know them. **I think it's difficult**; the Rambam may not take it literally. **But it does show prophecy isn't bearing a message**: we don't have 1.2 million books."

Part 5: Must a Prophet Be Jewish?

The Kuzari: only a Jew, only in Israel

Five levels: inanimate, plant, animal, human, which all the Rishonim accept, and a **fifth: the Jew**. **The Jew is inherently different.**

So **prophecy is a gift, only for a Jew**, and **only in Eretz Yisrael**. **Not even a convert**: "a full-fledged Jew for everything, but **an inferior kind of soul**" for this purpose.

Question (class): *How does the Kuzari explain Bilaam?*

The Gemara: Hashem gave the nations prophets **so they couldn't complain** *you had prophets and we didn't*. The Kuzari would need **a special exception**. "**I can't see him saying it here.** I'll check and **post it on the group**."

The Rambam: any human

"**I don't know anywhere the Rambam says the Jew is inherently different, and I don't believe he would.**" Prophecy **isn't a gift**: reach the perfection and you receive it, **Jew and non-Jew equally**. He always speaks of ***min ha'enoshi***, the human race.

But: Jews are more aligned to perfection, because **more mitzvot** means **more refinement**. "More susceptible, **not exclusive**."

The difficulty: Har Sinai

At **Matan Torah**, the whole people **heard Hashem**; the Midrash says they **fainted**, which many read as **prophecy**. **How did a nation of slaves suddenly reach that perfection?**

"**According to the Rambam it wasn't full-blown prophecy; it was a kind of philosophical revelation.** Obviously Har Sinai **fits better with the Kuzari's view**."

The prophetic experience itself

The Rambam and the Ramchal: the prophet is **stripped of his physical senses**; it feels as if **the body is turned inside out**; he **can't do anything else** and **must lie flat**.

Part 6: Is There Prophecy Today?

The Gemara: with the death of **Chaggai, Zechariah and Malachi**, early in the Second Temple, **the spirit of prophecy departed**.

For the Kuzari, simple: we're in **exile**; Hashem no longer gives it. **For the Rambam**, if someone reaches the three levels, **why not?**

Moreh 2:36: the **imaginative faculty can't be complete if a person isn't happy.**

- **Yaakov had no prophecy for 22 years**, mourning **Yosef**.

- **Music** was essential to inducing prophecy: **והיה כנגן המנגן ותהי עליו יד ה'** (Elisha).

The Rabbi's connection: the Gemara (Gittin; Sotah) forbids **music after the Churban**. By the strict letter (**Gemara, Rambam, Shulchan Aruch**) **live music is forbidden all year**, except perhaps at a wedding. "**Nobody keeps this halachah**, we go to concerts; **why is a different discussion**. But I think there's a link: **music was an ingredient of prophecy**, bringing **happiness**."

"**My understanding of the Rambam: not *impossible* today, but very, very hard. How can we be in exile, in servitude to the nations, without the Beit HaMikdash, and be fully happy?**"

Part 7: A First Look at Principle 7

היסוד השביעי: נבואת משה רבנו עליו השלום. והוא שנאמין כי הוא אביהם של כל הנביאים אשר היו לפניו ואשר קמו אחריו, כולם הם תחתיו במעלה, והוא היה נבחר מכל מין האדם, אשר השיג מאמתתו יתברך יותר מכל מה שהשיגו ושישיגו שום אדם שנמצא או שימצא.

Moshe is the father of all prophets before and after; all are **beneath him**. He grasped **more of Hashem's truth than anyone who ever was or will be**.

וכי הוא עליו השלום הגיע התעלותו מן האנושית אל המעלה המלאכותית ונכלל במעלת המלאכים, ולא נשאר מסך שלא קרעו... ולא מנעו ממנו מונע גופני, ולא נתערב לו שום חסרון בין רב בין מעט, ונתבטלו ממנו כוחות הדמיונות והחושים... ונשאר שכל בלבד. ועל הענין הזה נאמר עליו שהוא מדבר עם השם יתברך בלא אמצעות המלאכים.

Angelic level	He rose from the human to **the level of the angels**
No veil left	**He tore through every barrier** to understanding God
No deficiency	Nothing physical held him back; **a perfect human**
Pure intellect	Imagination, senses and **desires nullified**: **only intellect remained**
No intermediary	He spoke with Hashem **directly**, unlike other prophets, **through angels**

"I wanted to explain this..."

but it would need **many premises and parables**: **the angels and their levels** ("he hasn't written Mishneh **ורצוני היה לבאר זה הענין הנפלא, ולפתוח המנעול הנקוט בתורה, ולפרש ענין פה אל פה...**

Torah yet"), **the soul and its powers**, the forms the prophets described, and even ***Shiur Komah***.

Shiur Komah is a **Kabbalistic book**. "**He wrote this, and later erased it**: later in life he wrote **that the book was a fabrication**. **In the latest Rambams you won't find it.**"

ולא יספיק בענין זה לבדו אפילו אם יקוצר בתכלית הקיצור מאה דפים: **even a hundred pages, as brief as possible, wouldn't suffice.** So he leaves it for:

Promised book	What happened
ספר הדרשות (*derashot*: the book of)	**Never written**: as he said earlier, "**I'd need more *meshalim to explain the meshalim***"
ספר הנבואה ("writing which I'm busy")	**We don't have it.** "**I'm convinced he incorporated it into the second section of the Moreh.**"
A book explaining the principles	Again, **the Moreh**: three sections matching **the three categories**

Next week: the Rambam's **four differences between Moshe and all other prophets**.

A shocking text to leave with

The Arizal, quoted by **the Ba'al HaTanya** (the first of the seven **Chabad** Rebbes, ~250 years ago): **השגת משה רבינו עליו השלום לא היתה בבחינת פנימיות חכמה עילאה**: Moshe's grasp did **not** reach **the inner dimension of the highest *sefirot*** (**Chochmah, Keter**); **למעלה מנצח הוד יסוד מלכות לא היתה לו שום השגה בפנימיות**: above **Netzach, Hod, Yesod, Malchut**, **only external understanding**.

The Tanya asks: ולכאורה יפלא, הרי נאמר ולא קם נביא עוד בישראל כמשה, ואיך השיג האריז״ל יותר ממנו?

Answers: there's a great difference between the grasp of **חכמי האמת**, the **Rashbi and the Arizal** (**wisdom and knowledge**), and **Moshe's**, which was **prophecy**: **seeing**, as in **וראית את אחורי ופני לא יראו**.

"**On its face: Kabbalistic knowledge and prophetic knowledge are two disciplines. Moshe was a prophet, not a Kabbalist. The theological consequences are far-reaching. I think the Rambam would view this as completely heretical.** I find it shocking. **We have to be very careful with these things.**"

Question at the End

Who were the prophets before Moshe, and how did they learn without books?

Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov certainly: **"Hashem spoke to Avraham" is prophecy.**

"**Knowledge doesn't just come from books. Avraham gazed at the world** and understood it." And Chazal speak of **some learning even before the Torah**.

Avraham kept the Torah before it was given: "some take it literally. **The simple understanding:** he **attuned himself** to what the Torah would demand **a thousand years**

later, because **the Torah is the guide to perfecting *middot* and intellect**, and he reached that himself."

Summary

1. **Principle 6** opens **the second category (6–9)**: **Hashem relates to humanity**. It is **not** "the prophets' words are true" (that's **8–9**; the **Ani Ma'amin** is imprecise, **Yigdal** precise). It establishes **Hashem's involvement in the world** (**Ramban**: the plagues answered **Pharaoh**).
2. **Dreams** (true or false, **follow the interpretation**), ***Ruach HaKodesh*** (**intuition**, an ***einfall***) and **prophecy** (**a clear, transforming experience of cleaving to Hashem**), per **the Ramchal**. The Rabbi is **unsure the Rambam draws the same line**.
3. **Prophecy is an experience, not information**, and **doesn't endure** (*Bnei HaNevi'im*, **1.2 million prophets**).
4. **Who prophesies: the masses / Kuzari** (Hashem chooses), **philosophers** (automatic), **the Torah / Rambam** (**prepared, then Hashem's will**). **The miracle is *not* getting it.**
5. **Three ingredients: intellect** (Torah **and** the sciences), **character**, **imagination**.
6. **Kuzari: Jews only, in Israel. Rambam: any human**, though mitzvot help. **Har Sinai** fits the Kuzari better.
7. **No prophecy today:** for the Rambam, **without joy the imagination can't be complete**: exile, no Temple, **no music**.
8. **Principle 7: Moshe above all prophets**, pure intellect, **no intermediary**; the promised books became **the Moreh**; the **Arizal/Tanya** claim is "**shocking**."

Coming Up

Next week: finish **Principle 7**, the **four differences between Moshe and every other prophet**, then begin **Principle 8: *Torah min HaShamayim***, "which has lots to discuss."

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/McmeLI0OwRU · More shiurim: rabbikada.com